

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Pentecost 11

Another Kind of Freedom ~ Healing Division

16 August 2026



*Spurge (Euphorbia)
Photo from Unsplash*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Fugue on a Theme of Legrenzi, BWV 574 – Johann Sebastian Bach (1685-1750)
Kommt her zu mir, spricht Gottes Sohn, BuxWV 201 – Dietrich Buxtehude (1637-1707)
Le jardin suspendu – Jehan Alain (1911-1940)
Obra de mano derecha de medio registro de Torres – José de Torres (ca. 1670-1738)
Les petites cloches – Richard Purvis (1913-1994)
Fugue sur le thème du Carillon des Heures de la Cathédrale de Soissons, Op. 12 – Maurice Duruflé (1902-1986)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Lauren Seely & Rev. Lehman

We are inseparable from generations past
and generations future.
The lives of the ones who came before us
are present all around us.
The needs of those to come call upon us this day.

What are we doing with all we have inherited -
the wonderful and the terrible?
What will we leave behind?

*May the Holy things, the righteous things,
the things that make us brave in spirit
and fierce in hope
be our source of wisdom and guidance
as we strive to live faithfully-
to the Sacred
to each other
to those past and yet to come
in these perilous and precious days
we have been given.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

[-enfleshed]

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Holy Mystery

AUSTRIAN HYMN

Holy Mystery, Holy Wisdom, Wholly Love, who guides our way,
Loving Presence, Source of Being, now transform us day by day.
Words of Scripture tell our stories, voices rise in gifts of song,
Calling us to loving action, faith-filled as we journey on.

See the streams of living waters, springing from eternal love,
Wells supplying all that matters, and all fear of want remove;
Who can faint while such a river ever flows their thirst t'assuage?
Grace, which like our God, the Giver, never fails from age to age.

We are partners in creation, bound by love to all around,
Seeking justice and compassion, sharing truths that we have found.
Spirit - Source of Inspiration, Love - our song along the way,
Holy Mystery, Holy Wisdom –Source of hope with each new day.

***Prayer of Awareness and Confession**

Rev. Lehman

Holy One of freedom and liberation and reconciliation -
you have given us the law, spoken through prophets,
and provided us with the Spirit to help guide us
in love and justice.

Still we struggle.

The complexities of life and challenges of being human
often win over. In our pain we harm one another,
we do not intervene when our neighbors are targeted,
and we become possessive of power and resources.

Forgive us, O God.

And then, Gracious One,
ground our lives in mutual care and connection,
as we share with you - a vision of the belovedness
of each one of us, which is always and forever -
the cornerstone of your collective reality.

*For this and so much more, we are grateful.
Amen and Amen!*

[adpt/enfleshed]

***Introit**

Let All the World in Every Corner Sing
Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*, Dr. Emma Whitten, *Organ*

RALPH VAUGHAN WILLIAMS

***The Lord's Prayer**

Lauren Seely

*Mother of us all,
who dwells within and beyond,
Sacred is your name.
May your holy vision for collective flourishing
come to fruition among us.*

*May your dreams of justice, love, compassion,
and connection be enfleshed on earth.
Provide us today with what we need to be nourished
in body, soul, and heart.
Forgive us for the harm we cause as we seek to
forgive those who have harmed us.
Lead us away from everything that destroys
and liberate us from the hands of evil.
For you are the ultimate source of hope.
Your power-with exceeds all power over.
Your presence incites eternal wonder.
All praise to you, our comfort and strength.
Amen and Amen! [enfleshed]*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

In the center of the whirlwind
lies an eye.
Still.
Open.
Calm.
Before we come into the world,
it is as though we live in that center –
no worries,
no storms,
only peace.

As we find our way in this life,
even in the midst of chaos,
may we remember that center
and, as the need arises,
and it must,
may we hold
to the calm, open, stillness,
knowing it as home. [gvosper]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you.

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

from the Gospel of Luke

Lauren Seely

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People
Invitation to Silence and Prayer
Silence

Rev. Lehman

Prayer of Our Hearts

Gracious and Holy One,
we gather this morning
opening to your healing power.
We do not understand all the things
that make us whole,
nor the mystery of all that hurts us in body,
mind, and spirit.

But we do know this:
that the presence of the Christ,
the hidden wholeness coursing
through your wondrous universe,
weaves, from the dropped threads of unfinished lives,
a fabric of unmatched beauty.
We come this morning, O God,
seeking less to understand this Healing Source
than to open ourselves
to its sacred flow,
released in us
through this simple act of gathering -
singing, praying, and holding one another and our
beautiful, but often broken world -
in your love.

This we pray.

Amen. [adapt/bsanguin]

Meditation Anthem

That Which Can't be Explained

PETER ELDRIDGE arr. KATELYN DIETZ

Katelyn Dietz, Chohi Kim, Frank Hobbs, Kion Heidari, David Conley, *Small Ensemble*
Rohan Ramanam, *Soloist*, Katelyn Dietz, *Director*

Sermon

Healing Division

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Lauren Seely

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

Bože! Bože! Pisen novou
Anna Caplan, *Soloist*, Dr. Emma Whitten, *Piano*

ANTONIN DVORĀK

*I will sing a new song unto thee, O God: upon a psaltery
and an instrument of ten strings will I sing praises unto thee.*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Lauren Seely

*Holy Mystery,
we pray this morning ---
mindful of all that has brought us together,
of the Spirit of Life at work in our lives,
and of what may be possible
if we allow this Spirit to work
freely in each of us.*

*Let our generosity increase
as our lives are transformed
so that we may be
light and life in this place.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

Today we have gathered our courage in community because...
*We can do hard things
Brave things
Beautiful things
Risky and transformative things.*

The Sacred travels with those who journey toward freedom.
*For the sake of the collective life
For the sake of disrupting evil
For the sake of the human soul.*

We are called and companied,
never really alone.

*May our hearts be encouraged both this day -
and in all the days to come.*

[-enfleshed]

Amen and Amen!

Choral Response

Amen

KELLY MCCANDLESS

So let it be. So it shall be. Let us love one another. Amen.

*Hymn for the Journey

Come Now, O Wisdom

SLANE

Come now, O Wisdom, we need your clear voice;
Speak and awaken our hearts to rejoice.
Gracious Creator of more than we know,
In your own image may we ever grow.

Come now, O Wisdom, abide in our souls;
Stir in us visions of life free and whole.
Wisdom, your pathway to justice and peace,
With you our dreams find their fullest release.

Wisdom, more precious than rubies or gold;
With you our graces forever unfold.
No fame or fortune with you can compare;
Pour out your blessings, so rich and so rare.

Wisdom your grace joins all heaven and earth;
With you we labor new life to give birth.
Come now, O Wisdom, our Midwife and Friend,
Open our hearts to your world without end.

-lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

Postlude

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Fanfare, Op. 85 – C.S. Lang (1891-1971)

Inside The Music

“In our musical exploration today of *healing division*, we focus on that which unites us. We begin with the call for unity —*let all the world in every corner sing*— composed by the prominent 20th century British progressive social activist Ralph Vaughan Williams, whose work was informed by his ideals that the healing properties of music should be accessible for all and not reserved for the economic elite. We hear the urgency in his invitation through the insistence of the organ line and the rhythmic pulse of the choral homophony. Sometimes *love* sounds rousing! We meditate on the theme of healing with the tune and poem *That Which Can't be explained* by Peter Eldridge, arranged by Laude's own Katelyn Dietz. In it, the singer inquires about *differences unreconciled*, questions of *shaky refuge*, and the agnostic presence of spirit, connecting always to *loving that which can't be explained*. Sometimes *love* sounds intangible and uncertain!

Anna and Dr. Whitten then offer us an exclamation of praise from Psalms 144 and 145, *singing a new song unto the Earth with voice and strings*. Sometimes *love* sounds celebratory! And finally, we sing *Amen* —*let it be so*— in the Kelly McCandless sonic poem which explores the meaning of the word. In it, she discovers that *Amen*, to her, means *so let it be—so it shall be—we shall be who we are, one in the spirit. Let us love one another—Amen*. Sometimes, love sounds like radical acceptance and the healing of division.” ~ Dr. Ianthi Marini